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Can Letters Live Forever?
Designed by Cooper Jenkinson
Finalised on the 5th of June, 2025

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NaN Serf was designed by
the **NaN Team**, consisting of
Daria Cohen, Fadhl Haqq,
Leon Hugues, Jean-Baptiste Morizot,
Luke Prowse, Florian Runge
and Igino Marini.

Typography in contemporary
visual communication is like a
game of Tug of War, where the
design of a typeface is finding
the balance between centuries
of typographical evolutions and
a fresh design that is unique
enough to make it stand out.

NaN Serf is a typeface that does
a great job at employing this
idea in its design philosophy.

I think

NaN Serf

is cool.

Digital communication has
largely dominated the visual
landscape, with the choice of
typeface becoming both an act
of cultural preservation as well
as an innovation.

NaN Serf represents what I love
most about typography in that
it is simply enjoyable to stare
at. It is a typeface that honors
tradition whilst passionately
embracing the future.

Did You Know?

NaN is commonly found
in programming and is
short for ***“Not a Number.”***

Built upon the robust foundation of classical serif construction, the typeface initially presents familiar, comfortable proportions that invite extended reading.

A generous x-height for optimal legibility, balanced letter spacing, and the fundamental serif architecture that has served readers for centuries.

The lighter weights reveal NaN Serf's more traditional serif heritage, where the experimental elements whisper rather than shout.

Here, the typeface feels scholarly, refined,
and appropriate for extended text settings...

Dissecting

NaN

NaN

Ship

...but as the weight increases...

NaN Serf's true character emerges through its unconventional details. Sharp, angular incisions and squared terminals replace traditional rounded endings, creating a mechanical precision that feels both vintage and industrial.

The squared tittle and punctuation marks abandon circular tradition for geometric assertion creating visual anchors that catch the eye without disrupting reading flow.

... the unique characteristics amplify dramatically.

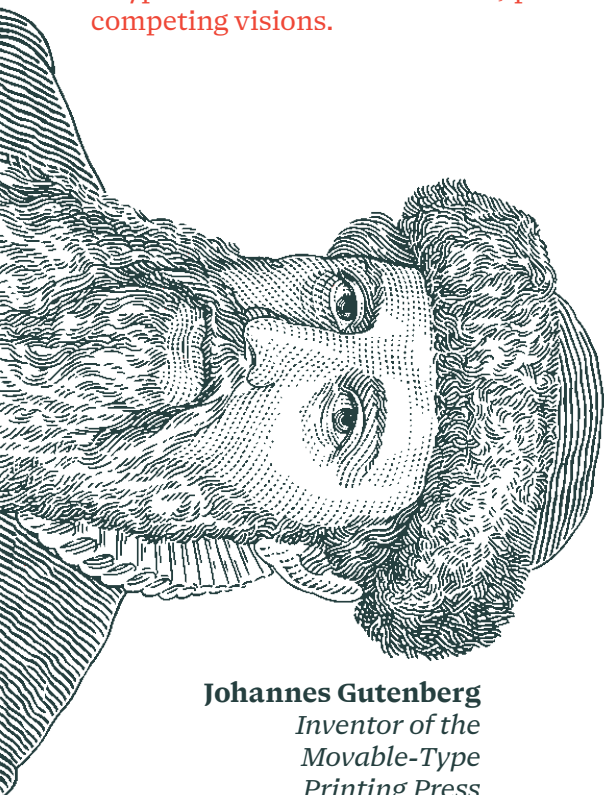
Heavier weights transform the typeface into something boldly contemporary, where those angular cuts become dramatic gestures and the squared elements create powerful rhythmic punctuation across the page.

A weight-dependent personality shift provides in making NaN Serf remarkably versatile, capable of serving both as a dependable text face and an expressive display typeface within the same family.

A Quiet Critique.

NaN Serf is powerfully contradictory.

It could be argued that NaN Serf's extensive development team, with multiple voices contributing to its evolution, has resulted in a typeface that feels indecisive, pulled in too many directions by competing visions.



Johannes Gutenberg
*Inventor of the
Movable-Type
Printing Press*

But I believe this collaborative complexity is precisely what makes NaN Serf so compelling and relevant in regards to our contemporary visual communication.

The multiple hands that built this typeface represent how typography itself evolved, not through isolated genius, but through a collective series of iterations since the dawn of the printing press.

NaN, founded by Luke Prowse, is a typography design team balancing weirdness and wisdom, with a mission to explore typography's relationship with code and technology.

Based between Berlin and Sydney, the foundry positions itself *"at the intersection of serious and slaphappy"*.



The diverse backgrounds that comprise NaN's team fundamentally embody the collaborative human evolution that drives contemporary typography forward.



Luke Prowse
Founder of NaN

NaN

Projects become “insane ping-pong games” where multiple designers contribute simultaneously to single typefaces, with files constantly changing hands and evolving through shared expertise. This methodology produces typography that no individual designer could achieve alone

“Both technically and stylistically, old designs are consistently made up-to-date by alive designers. NaN Serf is born out of this reflection”

NaN operates as a global collective, with team members spanning continents and specialisations such as diverse world scripts.

Armenian, Cyrillic, Devanagari, Georgian, Greek, and Hebrew.

NaN addresses critical gaps in contemporary typography through their internationally-minded approach and commitment to linguistic diversity.

This philosophy positions typography not as neutral communication tool but as cultural expression capable of joy, surprise, and delight.

Through their collective approach, NaN proves that contemporary type design thrives when diverse voices collaborate towards shared creative goals.

After decades of sans serif dominance in digital design, there has been a decisive turning point, a revival of the serif.

What began as nostalgic experimentation in luxury branding has evolved into a full-scale typographic renaissance. This resurgence started in high-end fashion and editorial design, where designers sought to differentiate brands from the infinite sea of Helvetica-inspired corporate identities.

Serifs
Never
Die.

Did You Know?
There's a *sans serif* version of this typeface named "**NaN Serf Sans.**"

In contemporary visual communication, this revival signals a profound cultural shift.

After years of pursuing algorithmic optimization and digital efficiency, designers and audiences crave the human touch that serifs inherently provide.

Do we know *Why?*

The serif's enduring appeal traces back to Roman stone inscriptions, where chisel marks naturally created the flared endings we recognize today.

These practical marks evolved through years of printing innovation, embedding themselves in our collective visual understanding as symbols of authority, craftsmanship, and permanence.

In type design, terminals are stroke endpoints that don't connect to other strokes. Most serif typefaces feature curved terminals following calligraphic traditions. However, NaN Serf employs orthogonal terminals, creating sharp geometric endpoints rather than flowing curves.

This technical choice serves multiple functions. At small sizes, orthogonal terminals provide crisp edges that maintain legibility when anti-aliasing softens other details.

The geometric precision creates consistent rhythm across letter combinations while maximizing counter openings, improving readability in digital spaces.

This systematic approach bridges historical letterforms with contemporary digital demands, proving effective innovations often hide in a typefaces's smallest details.

Oh! Just a quick
FYI*

*For Your
(typographic)
Information.

Creating this zine became an exploration of the very themes it examines. Researching NaN's distributed international team reinforced my central argument about collaborative evolution.

Just as the foundry's "insane ping-pong game" of shared creation produces innovative typography, my zine benefited from accumulated knowledge of type historians, design critics, and the NaN team's own insights.

It proved to me the possibility of

Letters Living
FOREVER...

The two-color constraint forced typography to carry the entire visual weight, treating letters as actors rather than mere carriers of meaning.

Every design decision had consequences across 16 pages, creating real-world design challenges that demanded both creativity and restraint.

Writing about typography deepened my practical understanding of typographic principles, and helped me understand that theory and practice inform each other in meaningful ways.

[illegible]

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